
The Self-Massage Toolkit

Companion Workbook — build your starter kit,
find what works for YOUR body, develop a
sustainable practice

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Inner Circle Deep Cut — #5 Workbook

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Introduction

A YEAR-LONG COMPANION TO THE IC5 DEEP CUT.
Build your starter kit, find what works for
YOUR body, and develop a sustainable practice.

CHAPTER 1

How to use this workbook

USE THE STARTER-KIT CHECKLIST FIRST. THEN the personalized technique tracker as you experiment. Then the seasonal check-ins quarterly.

Bring it to every session — I can give you specific recommendations based on what you're working on.

CHAPTER 2

My Starter Kit Inventory

What I currently own (check all that apply):

- ☐ Foam roller (basic smooth)
- ☐ Foam roller (textured/knobby)
- ☐ Foam roller (vibrating)
- ☐ Lacrosse ball
- ☐ Tennis ball
- ☐ Rice sock (homemade)
- ☐ Electric heating pad
- ☐ Theracane or Backnobber
- ☐ Percussion massager (Theragun, Hyperice, etc.)
- ☐ TENS unit
- ☐ Inversion table
- ☐ Other: _____

What I want to buy (based on IC5):

- ☐ Lacrosse ball (\$5)
- ☐ Tennis ball (\$3)
- ☐ Materials for rice sock (\$2)

- [] Foam roller (basic) (\$20-25)
- [] Theracane / Backnobber (if needed) (\$20-30)

TOTAL STARTER KIT BUDGET: \$___

Where I'll buy: _____

Date I'll have everything: ____

CHAPTER 3

Reflection Prompts

PROMPT 1: HOW MUCH MONEY HAVE YOU SPENT on self-massage / recovery products in the past few years? Be honest. Now look at what you actually use regularly. What's the ratio?

Spent: \$____

Actually use regularly: ____

What I learned from this:

Prompt 2: Which expensive product have you bought that turned out to be marketing more than substance? What did you actually need instead?

Prompt 3: Where in your body do you most reliably hold tension that you can self-address? Which tool from the toolkit fits that area best?

CHAPTER 4

Personalized Technique Tracker

FOR EACH AREA BELOW, MARK WHICH TOOLS work best for YOUR body and what timing feels right.

Neck

Tools that work for me: _____

Frequency: _____ times per week

When (morning, midday, evening): _____

Notes:

Shoulders / Upper Back

Tools: _____

Frequency: _____ times per week

When: _____

Notes:

Mid-Back

Tools: _____

Frequency: _____ times per week

When: _____

Notes:

Low Back

Tools: _____

Frequency: _____ times per week

When: _____

Notes:

Hips / Glutes

Tools: _____

Frequency: _____ times per week

When: _____

Notes:

Legs

Tools: _____

Frequency: _____ times per week

When: _____

Notes:

Feet

Tools: _____

Frequency: _____ times per week

When: _____

Notes:

Jaw / Face

Tools: _____

Frequency: _____ times per week

When: _____

Notes:

CHAPTER 5

My Daily Self-Massage Routine

BUILD THIS ONCE YOU'VE EXPERIMENTED FOR 2-4 weeks and know what works for YOUR body.

Morning (___ minutes)

1.

2.

3.

Midday (___ minutes)

1.

2.

Evening (___ minutes)

1.

2.

3.

CHAPTER 6

Safety Checklist (Read Before Doing Self-Massage)

AREAS I WILL AVOID:

- ☐ Front and sides of neck
- ☐ Directly over major joints
- ☐ Directly on the spine
- ☐ Over kidneys (lower back under floating ribs)
- ☐ Behind the knee
- ☐ Inner upper arm and thigh (major arteries)
- ☐ Varicose vein areas
- ☐ Acute injuries (first 48-72 hours)

I will STOP immediately if:

- ☐ Sharp shooting pain (not deep-release discomfort)
- ☐ Numbness or tingling
- ☐ Dizziness or nausea
- ☐ Spreading bruising

I will NOT do self-massage during:

- [] Pregnancy (without OB clearance for specific areas)
 - [] Active blood clots or DVT history
 - [] Active infection or fever
 - [] First 48-72 hours after acute injury
 - [] Recent surgery (without medical clearance)
-

CHAPTER 7

Seasonal Check-Ins

Spring

DATE: ____

Tools getting most use this season: _____

Areas needing more attention: _____

Summer

Date: ____

Tools getting most use this season: _____

Areas needing more attention: _____

Fall

Date: ____

Tools getting most use this season: _____

Areas needing more attention: _____

Winter

Date: ____

Tools getting most use this season: _____

Areas needing more attention: _____

CHAPTER 8

Year-End Toolkit Review

TOTAL SPENT ON SELF-MASSAGE TOOLS THIS
year: \$____

Most-used tools (top 3):

1.

2.

3.

Tools I bought but rarely use:

Marketing-driven purchases I regret:

Frequency of professional bodywork this year:
_____ sessions

Did the self-massage practice help my bodywork hold longer? [Yes / No / Unsure]

Commitment for next year:

CHAPTER 9

Try this for 7 days

IF YOU DO NOTHING ELSE FROM THIS WORKBOOK, try this:

Buy the starter kit. Lacrosse ball, tennis ball, foam roller. Under \$30 total. Use one tool, one area, for 5 minutes a day, every day, for one week.

That's the experiment. Don't try to use everything. Pick the tool that matches what's bothering you most right now and just use that one.

Most people are surprised by how much benefit comes from one focused 5-minute daily practice. Once you're consistent with one, add another.

Bring this workbook to your next session.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
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